

A humble man, and his prayer.

FOR EVERYONE, AND: CATECHUMENS, TAKE NOTE.

<http://www.orthodox.net/articles/isacc-the-syrian-a-humble-man-and-his-prayer.docx>

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I try to read St Isaac daily. I don't succeed, but I read him very often. St. Paisios of the Holy Mountain had a rule of reading two pages a day. Sometimes, I follow that rule, and sometimes, I read more. But that's because I'm not that obedient.

Sr Isaac's writing is beautiful and sublime and sometimes very "thick." By "thick," I mean it's not something you can read quickly, and you must reread it to understand it, even if only a little. I've read this passage two or three times.

It is so marvelous to see my sins exposed to me in such a gentle and beautiful way. Obviously, I am not a humble man. And I would venture to say that none of

you are HUMBLE, by St Isaac's definition. But we can become humble. What is impossible for man is possible for God.

And if we wonder what to pray, at the end of this passage is exactly what we should pray. I'm going to add it to my daily rule and use it all the time. And I would advise you to do it as well. Perhaps you could modify the prayer somewhat when somebody asks you to pray for them for a specific thing, or perhaps some detailed things; perhaps you could just say, "O Lord, may it be for thy servant... according to Thy will." Then we are at peace because we're asking God for the best for the one we pray for.

Read this slowly and luxuriously, and let your soul benefit from it.

A humble man is never rash, hasty, or perturbed, never has any hot and volatile thoughts, but at all times remains calm.

Even if heaven were to fall and cleave to the earth, the humble man would not be dismayed.

Not every quiet man is humble, but every humble man is quiet.

There is no humble man who is not self-constrained (or reserved, grave) ; but you will find many who are self-constrained without being humble.

This is also what the meek and humble Lord meant when He said, 'Learn of Me, for I am meek and humble of heart, and ye shall find rest unto your souls', For the humble man is always at rest, because there is nothing which can agitate or shake his mind. Just as no one can

frighten a mountain, so the mind of a humble man cannot be frightened.

If it be permissible and not incongruous, I should say that the humble man is not of this world. For he is not troubled and altered by sorrows, nor amazed and enthused by joys, but all his gladness and his real rejoicing are in the things of his Master.

Humility is accompanied by modesty and self-collectedness: that is, chastity of the senses; a moderated voice; mean speech; self-belittlement; poor raiment; a gait that is not pompous; a gaze directed toward the earth; superabundant mercy; easily flowing tears; a solitary soul; a contrite heart; imperturbability to anger; undistracted senses; few possessions; moderation in every need; endurance; patience;

fearlessness; manliness of heart born of a hatred for this temporal life; patient endurance of trials; deliberations that are ponderous, not light; extinction of thoughts; guarding of the mysteries of chastity; modesty; reverence; and above all, continually to be still and always to claim ignorance.

The humble man never encounters a necessity which could trouble and confuse him.

When he is alone, he even feels shame before himself. I should marvel greatly if there were any truly humble man who would venture to supplicate God when he draws nigh to prayer, or to ask to be accounted worthy of prayer, or to make entreaty for any other thing, or who would know what to pray.

For the humble man keeps a reign of silence over all his deliberations, and simply awaits mercy and

whatever decree should come forth concerning him from the countenance of God's worshipful majesty.

When he bows his face to the earth, and the divine vision within his heart is raised to the sublime gate leading to the Holy of Holies, wherein is He Whose dwelling-place is darkness which dims the eyes of the Seraphim and Whose brilliance awes the legions of their choirs and sheds silence upon all their orders ... then he dares only to speak and pray thus,

'May it be unto me according to Thy will, O Lord.'

And may we also say the same for ourselves. Amen.